

BHUPENDER YADAV *Union Minister of Environment, Forest & Climate Change*
● *Alwar, Rajasthan*



DHARMENDRA PRADHAN *Union Minister of Education, Skill Development & Entrepreneurship*
● *Sambalpur, Odisha*



BIPLAB DEB *Former Tripura chief minister*
● *Tripura West*



MANSUKH MANDAVIYA *Union Minister of Health & Family Welfare; Chemicals & Fertilisers*
● *Porbandar, Gujarat*



SARBANANDA SONOWAL *Union Minister of Ports, Shipping, Waterways*
● *Dibrugarh, Assam*



RAJEEV CHANDRASEKHAR *Minister of State for Skill Development and Entrepreneurship*
● *Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala*

● *Constituency the candidate is contesting from*

any accumulated *doshas* at Guna. Anurag Thakur is taking guard at Hamirpur, and Trivendra Singh Rawat at holy Haridwar. Even Piyush Goyal, whose career glided seamlessly from the boardrooms to the Upper House, has been handed a popular platform ticket at Mumbai North station. Not everyone may be bubbling over with combat-readiness, of course. Nirmala Sitharaman declined an offer to contest because she "did not have that kind of money". And S. Jaishankar, just a year into the Rajya Sabha, seemed genuinely hurt when a foreign correspondent wondered whether he was going to wade into the mudswamps of democracy. ■

But the Tamil landscape is full of spooky beings. Among the rivals who have suddenly cropped up are: Ochatthevar Pannerselvam (Bucket), Oyyadevar Panneerselvam (Grapes), Oyyaram Panneerselvam (Glass Tumbler), Ochappan Panneerselvam (Sugarcane Farmer) and M. Pannir Selvam (Peas). Besides, a video clip showing him giving Rs 1,000 to a woman welcoming him with aarti has ended in a formal EC complaint. OPS styles himself as the 'Coordinator' of the 'Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhaga Cadres Rights Retrieval Organisation' but, as he faces off toughies like the DMK-backed Indian Union Muslim League sitting MP Kani K. Navas and P. Jayaperumal of the AIADMK, there may be neither cadre nor organisation left to retrieve in the end. ■



▶ **WEST BENGAL**

The Revolution Will Be Webcast!

Shall we call it digital dialectics? The Left has long tried to shed the stereotype of being head-in-the-sand Luddites—one that it had earned back in the Eighties, the early days of computerisation, when it pressed the Ctrl X keys more than anything else. Behold the sheer spiffiness of the makeover, then, as a svelte AI anchoress named Samata (Equality) took to the digital soapbox at 9 pm on March 27, hosting a new biweekly show called 'Focus on Bengal'. In less than 48 hours, her first video was viewed by more than 74,000 people on the CPI(M) West Bengal Facebook handle and by over 43,000 people on the eponymous YouTube channel. Old comrades claim the numbers would be much higher if all other handles and platforms are counted. The first show spoke of an illegal building's collapse that killed 12. Expect some digitally manicured fire and brimstone on Sandeshkhali soon. Lenin, who knew a thing or two about using the radio as a weapon of mass dissemination, must be tut-tutting in impatience in some dacha up there. ■